Aquifer Open Study Notes (Profiles)

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I

Isaac

The name Isaac means "he laughs," which reflects how he was born. When God promised Isaac's birth, both Abraham and Sarah laughed in disbelief (Genesis 17:15–19; 18:9–15). God had promised Abraham a son (Genesis 15:4–6). But, no son had come, and Abraham and Sarah were too old to have children. So, when Isaac was born, they laughed with joy (Genesis 21:6–7).

When Isaac was a teenager, God tested Abraham by telling him to sacrifice Isaac (Genesis 22:1–19). Abraham's faith stayed strong. He obeyed and Isaac submitted to his. God then intervened and provided a ram to sacrifice instead of Isaac. Because of Abraham's faith, God promised him great blessings (Genesis 22:15–18).

Isaac married Rebekah and was ready to continue the chosen family line, but Rebekah could not have children (Genesis 25:21). Instead of trying to solve problems by himself as his father had done (see Genesis 16:1–16), Isaac prayed to the Lord, and Rebekah gave birth to twin sons. Isaac preferred Esau, the older son, while Rebekah preferred Jacob. This favoritism led to Jacob deceiving Isaac when he was old and blind (Genesis 27:1–40). Favoritism continued to be an issue among Isaac's descendants (see Genesis 29:30; 33:1–2; 37:4).

Isaac followed his father Abraham's example in dealing with nearby nations. During a famine, he visited another kingdom and, out of fear, said his wife was his sister (Genesis 26:1–11; compare 12:10–20; 20:1–18). Like his father, Isaac became wealthy in that land and was asked to leave (Genesis 26:12–16; compare 12:16–20). He faced disputes over water and land with other herdsmen (Genesis 26:17–22; compare 21:25–31). He also made a treaty with the king of the Philistines (Genesis 26:26–31; compare 21:22–32).

Isaac received the same promise as his father (Genesis 26:2–5, 23–25; compare 22:16–18). He showed his commitment by continuing the practice of circumcision, which symbolized the covenant (see Acts 7:8). As the child of promise, Isaac represents all who are Abraham's children through faith in Christ. They are free to live as God's children, not as slaves (see Galatians 4:21–5:1).

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 17:19–21; 21:1–12; 22:1–19; 24:1–8, 14, 62–67; 25:5–11, 19–28; 26:1–28:9; 31:42; 35:12, 27–28; 48:15–16; 49:31; Exodus 3:6; Joshua 24:3–4; Romans 9:6–10; Galatians 4:21–31; Hebrews 11:8–9, 17–20

Isaiah

Isaiah was a prophet from Judah during the reigns of Uzziah, Jotham, Ahaz, and Hezekiah. He was the son of Amoz (Isaiah 1:1). He might have been related to King Amaziah. Isaiah lived in Jerusalem, was well-educated, and greatly understood human nature. He served as a prophet for a long time, from about 740 to 685 BC. As Judah's political and religious advisor, he had access to kings and was likely the court historian (2 Chronicles 26:22; 32:32). Isaiah's wife was called a "prophetess" (see Study Note on Isaiah 8:3). Their sons were Shear-jashub and Maher-shalal-hash-baz (Isaiah 7:3; 8:3).

Isaiah opposed all social and political evil. He criticized fortune-tellers and rebuked kings for their stubbornness and indifference. He condemned wealthy, influential people who ignored their duties. He urged everyone to follow God's covenant. Isaiah opposed Canaanite idolatry and insincere religious practices (Isaiah 1:10–17; 29:13). He warned of judgment and stated that only a righteous few would survive (Isaiah 6:11–13). He predicted the coming Messiah, a peaceful prince of God's kingdom (Isaiah 9:6–7; 11:1–11). The Messiah would also be an obedient, suffering servant (53:3–12). The book of Isaiah has more connections to the New Testament than any other Old Testament book and is often quoted by New Testament authors.

Passages for Further Study

2 Kings 19:1–20:19; 2 Chronicles 26:22; 32:20, 32; Isaiah 1:1–66:24; Matthew 3:3; 4:14–16; 8:17; 12:17–21; 13:14–15; 15:7–9; Mark 1:2–3; 7:6–7; Luke 3:4–6; 4:17–19; John 1:23; 12:38–41; Acts 8:28–34; 28:25–27; Romans 9:27–29; 10:15–16, 20–21; 15:12; Galatians 4:27

Ishmael

Ishmael was Abraham's first son, born to Hagar, Sarah's Egyptian servant. The boy was born near Hebron when Abraham was eighty-six years old (Genesis 13:18; 16:16). God promised to make a great nation from the childless Abraham (Genesis 12:2). God assured him he would have a son as his heir (15:4). Ishmael was born when Abraham tried to fulfill God's promise by human means (see Genesis 16:1–16; Galatians 4:23). But God would still achieve his purposes through Sarah (see Genesis 17:15–18:15; 21:1–7).

God said Sarah would have a son to fulfill the promise (Genesis 17:15–16). Abraham asked God to accept Ishmael (17:17–18). Ishmael was not the promised son

because God's special agreement (covenant) would be with Isaac (Genesis 17:19). Still, God blessed Ishmael and made him the father of a great nation (Genesis 17:20–21).

When Ishmael was thirteen, he was circumcised as part of God's covenant with Abraham (Genesis 17:9–14, 23–27). At Isaac's weaning celebration, when Ishmael was about seventeen, he mocked Isaac (Genesis 21:9). As a result, Abraham sent Ishmael and Hagar away with supplies. An angel of God helped Hagar survive in the wilderness, and Ishmael became a hunter. He settled in the wilderness of Paran and married an Egyptian woman (Genesis 21:20–21). Ishmael helped bury Abraham (Genesis 25:9–10). He gave his daughter Mahalath in marriage to Esau (28:9). Abraham died at age 137 (25:17). His twelve sons are listed in Genesis 25:13–15.

Paul mentioned Ishmael to encourage the Galatians to trust in God instead of the law (see Galatians 4:21–31). Those who rely on the law will not inherit the kingdom, just as the slave woman's son did not inherit with the free woman's son (Galatians 4:30).

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 16:11–16; Genesis 17:18–26; 21:8–21; 25:9–18; 28:9; Galatians 4:21–31